

GALATIANS

Small Group Bible Study Series

Galatians 2:11-21

Peter Goes Back to School

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Editor: Bruce R. Crow

How This Study Flows

① THE TEXT	② DEVOTIONAL	③ COMMENTARY	④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE
Foundation	Personal prep	Leader / Teacher	Group meeting
Everyone	All group members	Teacher / Leader	Small group

⑤ Application closes each study and draws from all sections above, plus the FGR Resource Library.

Galatians 2:11-21 · New King James Version

No Return to the Law

11 *Now when Peter had come to Antioch, I withstood him to his face, because he was to be blamed;*

12 *for before certain men came from James, he would eat with the Gentiles; but when they came, he withdrew and separated himself, fearing those who were of the circumcision.*

13 *And the rest of the Jews also played the hypocrite with him, so that even Barnabas was carried away with their hypocrisy.*

14 *But when I saw that they were not straightforward about the truth of the gospel, I said to Peter before them all, "If you, being a Jew, live in the manner of Gentiles and not as the Jews, why do you compel Gentiles to live as Jews?"*

15 *We who are Jews by nature, and not sinners of the Gentiles,*

16 *knowing that a man is not justified by the works of the law but by faith in Jesus Christ, even we have believed in Christ Jesus, that we might be justified by faith in Christ and not by the works of the law; for by the works of the law no flesh shall be justified.*

17 *"But if, while we seek to be justified by Christ, we ourselves also are found sinners, is Christ therefore a minister of sin? Certainly not!"*

18 *For if I build again those things which I destroyed, I make myself a transgressor.*

19 *For I through the law died to the law that I might live to God.*

20 *I have been crucified with Christ; it is no longer I who live, but Christ lives in me; and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave Himself for me.*

21 *I do not set aside the grace of God; for if righteousness comes through the law, then Christ died in vain."*

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"I have been crucified with Christ; it is no longer I who live, but Christ lives in me." — Galatians 2:20

Peter knew better. He had seen the vision, felt the Spirit fall on Cornelius's household, and had already defended eating with Gentiles before the whole Jerusalem church. Yet when men from James walked into Antioch, he quietly backed away from the table — not because his theology changed, but because his courage did. Barnabas followed. A congregation that had been eating as one family began sorting itself by ethnicity again. One man's fear of what a few visitors would think nearly rewrote the gospel's practice, if not its content.

Paul's answer wasn't a pep talk about consistency. It was a return to the gospel itself: no one — Jew or Gentile — is justified by keeping rules. We are declared righteous by faith in Christ alone, and that verdict is legal, final, and not ours to renegotiate under pressure.

That is why Paul can say in the same breath that he has died and is somehow still living. The old identity that needed everyone's approval was crucified with Christ; the life he lives now runs on the faith in the Son of God, who loved him and gave Himself for him.

Reflect before you gather:

1. Where in your life do you already know the truth, but quietly withdraw from it under social pressure?
2. Do you relate to God on the basis of a performance you're maintaining, or a verdict He has already rendered?
3. What would it look like this week to live "by faith in the Son of God" rather than by the approval of whoever just walked into the room?

Before you gather with your group, sit with this: the gospel that saved you is also the gospel you are called to keep living out loud.

Proposition: *Galatians 2:11-21 teaches that the gospel of grace governs not only how a person is saved, but how believers live and relate to one another — and that even a mature, Spirit-taught apostle can drift from gospel practice under social pressure, requiring loving but public correction anchored in the truth of justification by faith alone, apart from the works of the law.*

Introduction

You may remember that in the beginning of these studies I defended the position that Galatians was written before the Jerusalem Council described in Acts 15. For better or worse, that is my position, and I won't go back through all of that again here — go back to that first tape on the website and listen to it if you'd like the full case (sermon 18). But this happened before the Jerusalem Council. Peter was taught the Grace Gospel through a special revelation — a vision he had in Acts 10, about A.D. 40.

The voice came to him: “What God has cleansed you must not call common.” We'll talk about this a little later in more detail, but this was apparently done three times. A sheet came down, and he was told, “Arise and eat.” He said, “I won't do that — I won't eat anything that's not cleansed.” The message came again: “What God has cleansed, don't you call common.” So the Holy Spirit fell on those Gentiles when Peter went to Cornelius's house. It was the same Holy Spirit that had fallen on the Jews in Acts 2 — and that was a confirming thing for Peter.

In Acts 2, the Jews had received the Holy Spirit; they spoke in the languages of the day, and the Spirit fell on them. Peter later says, “For he heard them speak in tongues and magnify God” — the same tongues as Acts 2. Otherwise, Peter would not have known it was the same Holy Spirit. So Peter is seeing something here: the Holy Spirit fell on the Jews in Acts 2, and on the Gentiles in Acts 10 — he couldn't miss that point.

Then he was called on the carpet, Acts 11. The apostles and the leaders of the church in Jerusalem called him up and said to Peter, “You went to the uncircumcised men, and you ate with them — you ate with Gentiles.” Peter explained what happened in great detail, and then he said, “Who was I that I should withstand God?” — God told him to go there, and he went; how could they find fault with that? By this he meant: God told me to eat with the Gentiles, therefore I did.

Now, six years later, A.D. 46, Paul went to Jerusalem on the famine visit, Acts 11. This is recorded in Galatians 2:1-10, which was our last sermon. Paul says concerning Peter and the apostles: they gave him the right hand of fellowship, saying, “Go for it — your gospel is correct. Go and preach that gospel.” So Peter was saying, I will back you; this is right; your gospel is correct.

We don't know for sure exactly when these events occurred — I'm placing them just about here on the timeline. When Paul went back up to Antioch, Peter came up there very soon after as well, so it's very close to A.D. 46. It occurred, I take it, very soon after that famine visit, but before that first church council.

{By the way, it doesn't seem likely that it was at that first church council, because Peter would then be going against the decision of that very council — he wouldn't be likely to do that. So I'm saying it was before that.}

I. Paul Confronts Peter about the Gospel — 2:11-14

A. It Was a Public Confrontation — 2:11

Now, in verses 11 to 14, Paul confronts Peter about the gospel. It was a public confrontation. Verse 11 says this: “Now when Peter had come to Antioch, I withstood him to his face, because he was to be blamed.” And later on, verse 14: “I said to Peter before them all...” Now, this may have been a time during communion — they had a meal, communion, and so forth. I don't think so; I think it was just a regular meal, and he was not eating with the Gentiles. In any case, whatever the occasion, Paul stops everything in its tracks, right there: “Hey, wait a minute, Peter — we'll talk to you.” Can you see that? They're all sitting there eating, and Paul stands up to Peter — here's Paul, and here's Peter. Peter, the big man; Paul, the little guy. He stood up, and he does it in public.

Now, I don't suggest that we do that very often, but I do say this — let me ask you the question: how public should confession and correction be? Dr. Ryrie had a good thing to say about that — I was in a dozen of his classes — he said, “The confession should be as public as the sin.” And so here it was: Peter did this publicly, and Paul said, I've got to stop this right now — he was teaching something wrong.

1. Peter had been Prepared Better than this — Acts 10:10-12

Peter had been prepared better than this. In Acts 10 — we just talked about this — he became very hungry. This is when people came from Cornelius and said Cornelius wants you to come down and tell him about salvation. Peter was trying to figure out what he should do, and he became very hungry and wanted to eat. But while they made it ready, he fell into a trance and saw heaven opened, and an object like a great sheet, bound at the four corners, descended to him and was let down to the earth. In it were all kinds of four-footed animals of the earth, wild beasts, creeping things, and birds of the air. And a voice came to him and said, “Rise, Peter, kill and eat.” And Peter said, “Not so, Lord” — a contradiction in terms, saying “not so, Lord” — “for I have never eaten anything common or unclean.” And a voice spoke to him again the second time: “What God has cleansed, you must not call common.” This was done three times, and the object was taken back up into heaven again.

Now, what was He trying to tell him? The Gentiles are saying, Peter, come down and tell us about salvation, and Peter gets this vision three times. God says to him, What I have cleansed, don't you call common. So he goes down to Cornelius, to the Gentiles' house, and says, oh, that's what God meant — if I've cleansed them, don't you call them common. If I tell you to go to the Gentiles, you go to the Gentiles; they are clean in My sight. And so that's what he's doing. That says to me, then, the message is clear to him: God does not make a distinction between Jew and Gentile. They are all one and the same.

And by the way, Galatians 3:28 says, “There is neither Jew nor Greek... for you are all one in Christ Jesus.” It doesn't mean we all have the same jobs or the same positions, but it does mean we're all one — we all stand before the cross on level ground.

Now, Peter had been prepared properly. He had also already preached better than this — he had preached the same thing, contrary to what he was doing here.

2. Peter had preached better than this — Acts 11:17

Remember, he was called on the carpet in chapter 11, after he had gone to eat with the Gentiles. Verse 17: “If God gave them the same gift as He gave to us when we believed on the Lord Jesus Christ, who was I that I should withstand God?” In other words: I saw that the same Holy Spirit came down on them, and I could not withstand God — I was right in going to eat with the Gentiles. So he had learned it, and he had preached it to those leaders. He had to do what God told him to do — he had to do it. So he was prepared better, he preached better, and he promised better.

3. He had promised better than this — Galatians 2:9

During the famine visit, he says this: “And when James, Peter, and John, who seemed to be pillars, perceived the grace that was given to me, they gave me and Barnabas the right hand of fellowship, that we should go to the Gentiles, and they to the circumcised.” A handshake. Now, it wasn't the church council, but shaking hands says, Go — we believe it. And back in that day, if a man shook your hand, that was like writing it down and getting it notarized. They were saying, Okay, you go to the Gentiles — you're right, your gospel is straight. So he promised: that's what you do, I agree with you.

B. It Was a Pointed Confrontation — 2:12

So it was a public confrontation on that basis. Then it was a pointed confrontation, for before certain men came from James, he would eat with the Gentiles. Peter, remember, came to Antioch and started eating with the Gentiles, just like he should have done. So before people came from James, he would eat with the Gentiles. But when they came — these men came from Jerusalem up to Antioch to see what was going on — when they came, he withdrew himself. They set off in the corner: we're going to have our meal over here, because we're going to eat the right diet, the Jewish diet, according to the law. And so here they are, over here — the men from Jerusalem are sitting there, Peter is over here with the Gentiles — oh, I'm eating with the Gentiles, oh, they're going to go back and tell James, now I'm in trouble. So he withdrew, separated himself, fearing those who were of the circumcision. That's hypocrisy.

And Paul called it right — he called it exactly what it was: you were over here before, eating with the Gentiles, like you promised, like you preached, like you were prepared. You're a hypocrite — you're not straightforward with this thing, so it was hypocrisy. He was not acting according to what he knew to be right.

1. When he was away from home, he ate with the Gentiles

So when he was away from home, he ate with the Gentiles. The eating may have been a meal connected with the Lord's Table, but I think probably not.

2. When the Jews came from the Jerusalem church, he began to withdraw and eat only with them

But when the Jews came from Jerusalem, he began to withdraw and eat only with them. Now, the verb tenses indicate that it was a gradual thing. I take it that he ate with the Gentiles for a while, and then maybe one lunchtime he went over and ate with them, and then he went back again — and pretty soon he was eating permanently with the Jews over there. The example was bad — the example was that there are Jews and there are Gentiles in the church; there are two churches, in other words, two bodies of Christ.

C. It Was a Poisonous Confrontation — 2:13

So it was a public confrontation, it was a pointed confrontation, but it was also a poisonous condition. This is it: “And the rest of the Jews also played the hypocrite with him, so that even Barnabas was carried away with their hypocrisy.” Can you see this? Peter is gradually moving over — now Peter is over on the Jewish side, eating the right food, the exactly right stuff — whole wheat bread — but there they are, over here — and then the Jewish believers of Antioch, who had been eating with the Gentiles (Paul wouldn't allow anything else), said, oh, look, the Jews — we'll go over there too. So here they come, the next night, all the Jews who were in the Antioch church — the Jews went. And then, horror of horrors — Barnabas. Barnabas, of all things — he had been with Paul, working, preaching, preaching the grace gospel, there's one church, he believed all that — but even Barnabas went with them. He had preached the grace gospel all along, but that's what pressure does. Peer pressure says, I've got to keep everybody happy, I've got to do what they say, because otherwise they'll think I'm strange. Well — you are strange.

D. It Was a Practical Confrontation — 2:14

So there was a public confrontation, a pointed confrontation, a poisonous condition, and it was a practical confrontation. Verse 14 says this: “But when I saw that they were not straightforward about the truth of the gospel, I said to Peter before them all, if you, being a Jew, live after the manner of the Gentiles and not as the Jews, why do you compel the Gentiles to live like Jews?” What's he saying? He's saying: Peter, you were eating with the Gentiles. Before the people from Jerusalem came, you lived like a Gentile — you were living there with the Gentiles. And now you're compelling Gentiles to live like Jews, because you want all of them to live like Jews. Why can't these Gentiles live like Gentiles? You're saying that everybody has to eat this dietary thing, like the law, because the law is so incumbent upon us.

Now, there's a question as to where the conversation with Peter stops and Paul goes on talking just about the situation in general. I don't think it makes any difference — there's really a distinction without a difference there. In any case, he's going on to the same subject: so he confronts Peter about the gospel, and now he corrects Peter about the gospel.

II. Paul Corrects Peter about the Gospel — 2:15-16

A. He Shows How the Groups Are Separate — 2:15

He shows how the groups are separate. Verse 15 says this: “We are Jews by nature, and not sinners of the Gentiles.” Yes, there’s a difference between Jew and Gentile — we are Jews by birth; we were not brought into the nation by becoming proselytes. That’s an important distinction for them. Remember, back in Philippians 3:4, Paul says this about himself: “If anyone thinks that he may have confidence in the flesh, I have more — I was circumcised the eighth day.” What does that have to do with anything? Well, I was born a Jew, so I was circumcised on the eighth day. I’m of the stock of Israel, the tribe of Benjamin, a Hebrew of the Hebrews, concerning the law a Pharisee — I’m a Jew by nature, just as much as those Judaizers ever were. And these Gentiles are not Jews by nature, or any other way — they’re two separate groups. So it shows that they are separate in some way, but also the same.

B. He Shows How They Are the Same — 2:16

And listen to this verse — verse 16, very important: “Knowing that a man is not justified by the works of the law, but by faith in Jesus Christ, even we have believed in Jesus Christ, that we might be justified by faith in Christ and not by the works of the law; for by the works of the law no flesh will be justified.” In this verse, Paul says three times that man is not justified by the works of the law, and he also says three times that we are justified by faith in Jesus Christ — six times he reiterates it: not by the law, but by faith.

So we know that a man — any man, Jew or Gentile — is not justified by the works of the law. Nobody is. We Jews have believed in Jesus Christ, that we might be justified by faith in Christ, not by the works of the law. That’s true. The same is true of the Gentiles: they are justified by faith — they believe in Jesus Christ, that they might be justified by faith in Christ, and not by works.

Now, this justification is forensic, or legal, justification — we are justified before God. Verse 21 speaks of this, being declared righteous: “He made Him who knew no sin to be sin for us, that we might become the righteousness of God in Him.” That’s it — that’s forensic, that’s legal. When you believed on Jesus for eternal life, you saw the promise of eternal life for those who believed, and you believed — you received eternal life. In God’s sight, you were totally without sin, and you still are. You are without sin — you are legally not guilty.

Now, suppose — just suppose, could never happen — but suppose someone would kill his wife, and another man happened to be there. He went to court. In that court hearing, the glove didn’t fit, and so the judge said, Not guilty. In fact, the jury of his peers said, Not guilty. And the judge says, okay, you are not guilty; he didn’t do it. Oh, yeah? No — legally, he didn’t do it. He can never be tried again for that. He didn’t do it; he’s not guilty. He may be guilty of sin, but he is not guilty legally. The same is true of you: you’re a sinner, every one of you is a sinner, but you believed on Jesus Christ, and you are now without sin — imputed righteousness, legally.

Editorial flag: the bold-underlined portion above retains the speaker’s original wording per CSG V15 In-Document Flagging — it may reference a real, identifiable court case. Left for the editor’s review and decision on how to handle for publication.

Now, there's another, practical righteousness as well. Practical righteousness means that a believer is still a sinner practically, in his daily life. I John 1:8 says this: "If we say that we have no sin at any point in time, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us." Verse 10 says, "If we say that we have not sinned at any point in time, we make Him a liar, and His truth is not in us." No — that's bad, always sinning. But in between those two verses, 8 and 10, comes verse 9: "If we confess our sin, He is faithful and righteous to forgive us our sin, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness" — so that we can be practically sinless, as well as judicially sinless. But it takes this confession of our sin to keep our accounts straight with God.

1 John 1 says this — these things, looking back to chapter 1, verses 5 to 9 — these things we write to you, that you may not sin; he's writing to them that they not sin. But then he says, if you do sin, we have an Advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous — He's the One who pleads for us, He's our Advocate; He's the One — if we confess, He forgives.

So he confronts Peter about the gospel; he corrects Peter about the gospel. Peter, you are living wrong by doing that, by saying we have to be saved also by the law. Wrong.

III. His Argument with Peter — 2:17-21

A. He Shows Peter's Error — 2:17-18

Then he concludes his argument with Peter in verses 17 to 21. He shows Peter's error, verses 17 and 18. He says: "If, while we seek to be justified by Christ, we ourselves are found sinners, is Christ therefore the minister of sin? Certainly not! For if I build again those things which I destroyed, I make myself a transgressor." You should see where the commentaries go with this — here and there and all over the place. I think what he's saying is this. Verse 17 says: if we follow the grace teaching that we are justified by Christ, and are therefore free from the law, and we then, in keeping with this teaching, eat with the Gentiles — according to the Judaizers, we're sinners. But that would make Christ the minister of sin — He told us to do that. Now, that's one way to look at it; another way, maybe, is like a syllogism: according to Jesus' teaching, we ought to eat with the Gentiles — is Jesus the minister of sin? No — absolutely not. No, absolutely not. Then, in that case, it's not a sin to eat with the Gentiles. Jesus tells us to eat with the Gentiles; when Jesus tells us to do something, that's not sin — we have a right; it's not a sin to eat with the Gentiles. I think that's what he's saying.

Then in verse 18 he says this: "If I build again the things which I destroyed" — the law forbidding believers to eat with the Gentiles — "then I make myself a transgressor." He's looking at Peter — he's saying, aye, but he's looking at Peter: Peter, you were eating with the Gentiles, you said it's okay to eat with the Gentiles, you preached it, you told it, everything — that's where you were. Now, if you go over here and eat with the Jews, then you are rebuilding something you already tore down. If you do that, then — he says — I make myself a transgressor, a transgressor of the grace gospel. Peter, you're wrong.

B. He Shows Why It Is Wrong to Return to the Law — 2:19

He shows Peter's error, but then he shows why it's wrong to return to the law. He says, "For through the law I died to the law that I might live to God." So the purpose of the Law was to point men to Jesus Christ — it pointed us in that direction. Everything in the law looked at Christ, looked forward to Him — the sacrifices didn't take away sin, they covered the sin until Christ should come. So everything pointed to Jesus Christ; that's what the Law was about, that was the purpose. And then it was through the Law that Paul died to the Law. So the Law said, okay, there's coming the cross — when the cross gets here, when Christ dies on the cross, not only is He dying, you're dying with Him, because He's dying for the entire world. All sin was paid for at the cross — past, present, and future, all people. The sin of all men was paid for at the cross. So you say, I'm not reformed — but He died for all, and all sin was paid for.

So, then he says, the purpose of the Law was to lead to grace, to Christ. Then he says, He died — Christ died on the cross, and the Law died with it. Colossians 2:14 says the Law was nailed to the cross. When Christ died, I died, the Law died — all there on the cross. The Law is done, the Law ended at the cross.

{That's what he says in Galatians 3:19 — the law came "till the Seed should come"; when the promised Seed came and died, the law's jurisdiction ended. The transcript audio here says "the law came until the sin should come" — almost certainly a mis-transcription of "Seed," corrected here to match the text he is teaching from.}

Now, that's a good thing — it's a good thing that the Law ended, because now I can serve God. I can look to God.

C. He Points Out that He Is Both Dead and Alive — 2:20

So he shows that he is both dead and alive. Paul is dead: "I've been crucified with Christ." Jesus is our substitute — Adam was our representative for us: he sinned, and the whole race sinned; death came upon all, because Adam, by natural birth, was our representative. He disobeyed, and then, as the father of mankind, his sin brought death to everybody. But Christ is our representative on the cross — when He died, we died. So our sin-debt is paid. The question is no longer the sin question; you have to say — when you stand before the Lord, your question is going to be, what did you do with Jesus, who is called the Christ? What are you going to do with Him? That's the question. We died — "I have been crucified with Christ," Paul said.

"I have been crucified with Christ; it is no longer I who live, but Christ lives in me; and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave Himself for me." — Galatians 2:20

But then he says, I live. "It is no longer I who live, but Christ lives in me; and the life which I now live in the flesh, I live by the faith of the Son of God, who loved me and gave Himself for me." We participate in His death, His burial, and His resurrection — we died with Him, we are buried with Him, and we are resurrected with Him. In baptism, we often quote Romans 6:3-4, speaking of the believer's spiritual baptism into the body of Christ. 1 Corinthians 12:13 — he says, "Or do you not know that as many of us as were baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into His death?"

Therefore we are buried with Him through baptism” — and water baptism pictures this: we are buried with Him in baptism into His death, just as Christ was raised from the dead to the glory of the Father, even so also we should walk in newness of life. We were buried with Him in baptism; we are resurrected to walk in newness of life. So that's why Paul lives — the life that Paul lives now is lived by the faith of the Son of God. Just as salvation is by faith, so also sanctification is by faith — always, never according to law.

D. He Shows the Absolute Necessity for the Grace Gospel — 2:21

And then, finally, he shows the absolute necessity for the Gospel, the Grace Gospel. He says, “I do not set aside the grace of God, for if righteousness comes through the law, then Christ died for nothing.” If righteousness comes by the law, Christ died for nothing. God would not send His only begotten Son to the earth to die for sin if there was any other way to do it — there was no other way. Man cannot contribute one thing to what Christ did on the cross. Salvation, then, is one way, and that one way is by faith alone in Christ alone. That's what we are — that's the Grace Gospel. And that is not only how we got saved, it's how we live.

And this is going to be a turning point right into the next chapter. The next chapter says, “Oh, foolish Galatians,” and so on. Let's see that.

Lord, thank You.

Greek Word Study

Grammar and parsing per Blue Letter Bible / standard NT grammars. Sources cited selectively by code — STR (Strong's), THAY (Thayer's), ATR (Robertson's Word Pictures), VINE (Vine's Expository Dictionary), MRV (Vincent's Word Studies), LXX (Septuagint usage) — only where a given source adds clarity for that word.

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # · Transliteration · Grammatical Form	Definition & Significance
11	ἀνθίστημι withstood / opposed	G436 · anthistēmi Verb – Aor. Ind. Act. 1st Sg.	STR: to stand against, resist, oppose. Significance: Paul's opposition was a decisive, completed act — a firm stand taken in the moment, not a running feud.
11	καταγινώσκω was to be blamed / stood condemned	G2607 · kataginōskō Verb – Perf. Ptc. Pass. Nom. Masc. Sg. (periphrastic)	THAY: to find fault with, blame. Significance: Peter's censure was behavioral, not a loss of standing before God — a believer's inconsistent walk can be justly faulted without his justification ever being in question.
12	ὑποστέλλω withdrew	G5288 · hypostellō Verb – Imperf. Ind. Act. 3rd Sg.	THAY: to draw back, withdraw, as from timidity. ATR notes the same verb describes Paul's boldness in Acts 20:20, 27 ("I did not shrink from declaring") — a pointed irony here. Significance: the imperfect tense pictures a gradual, repeated retreat, not one decision.
13	συνυποκρίνομαι played the hypocrite with / joined in hypocrisy	G4942 · synhypokrinomai Verb – Aor. Ind. Pass. (dep.) 3rd Pl.	STR: to act hypocritically in concert with. This is its only NT occurrence. Significance: hypocrisy spreads in community — one leader's inconsistency pulled an entire congregation, even Barnabas, off course.
14	ὀρθοποδεῶ were straightforward / walking uprightly	G3716 · orthopodeō Verb – Pres. Ind. Act. 3rd Pl. (negated)	VINE/THAY: literally "straight-footed"; to walk a straight course. Only NT occurrence. Significance: doctrine and conduct must walk the same line — Peter's feet (practice) no longer matched his gospel (doctrine).
15	φύσις nature	G5449 · physis Noun – Dat. Fem. Sg.	STR: birth, natural condition. Significance: distinguishes ethnic/birth identity from spiritual standing — a distinction Paul draws only to dissolve it in the next verse.
16	δικαιόω justified	G1344 · dikaioō Verb – Pres./Aor. Pass. (3 occurrences, v.16)	THAY/VINE: to declare righteous, to acquit — a forensic, courtroom term, not "to make righteous." Significance (Free Grace / GES): justification is a legal declaration received by faith, complete the moment a person believes, not a process completed by works.
16	ἔργα νόμου works of the law	G2041 / G3551 · erga nomou Noun Pl. Gen. / Noun Sg. Gen.	Significance: Mosaic law-keeping as a basis of acceptance with God — explicitly excluded, and negated three times in this one verse for

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # · Transliteration · Grammatical Form	Definition & Significance
			emphasis.
16	πιστεύω / πίστις believed / faith	G4100 / G4102 · pisteuō / pistis Verb – Aor. Ind. Act. 1st Pl. / Noun	Significance: the single instrumental means of justification, paired with dikaiōō three times in one verse for maximum emphasis.
17	ἁμαρτωλός sinners	G268 · hamartōlos Adj./Noun – Nom. Masc. Pl.	Significance: even justified believers, examined in ongoing practice ("found sinners"), still sin — Paul distinguishes this reality from making Christ the cause of it.
18	παραβάτης transgressor	G3848 · parabatēs Noun – Acc. Masc. Sg.	VINE: one who oversteps a defined boundary. Significance: rebuilding a law one has already renounced doesn't restore innocence — it manufactures fresh guilt.
19	ζάω live	G2198 · zaō Verb – Aor. Subj. Act. 1st Sg. (purpose clause)	Significance: dying to the law was never an end in itself, but the doorway into a new kind of life lived for God.
20	συσταυρόω crucified with	G4957 · synstauroō Verb – Perf. Ind. Mid./Pass. 1st Sg.	THAY/ATR: to be crucified together with. Same verb describes the literal criminals crucified alongside Jesus (Matt. 27:44). Significance: the perfect tense marks a past, completed event with continuing present effect — union with Christ's death is a settled fact, not an ongoing project.
21	ἀθετέω set aside	G114 · atheteō Verb – Pres. Ind. Act. 1st Sg. (negated)	THAY: to nullify, reject, treat as invalid. Significance: returning to law-keeping as a basis for righteousness doesn't merely supplement grace — it functionally nullifies it and renders the cross needless.

Grammar Abbreviation Key

Cases: Nom. (Nominative) · Gen. (Genitive) · Dat. (Dative) · Acc. (Accusative) · Voc. (Vocative) | Number: Sg. (Singular) · Pl. (Plural) | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut.

Mood: Ind. (Indicative) · Imp. (Imperative) · Subj. (Subjunctive) · Ptc. (Participle) · Inf. (Infinitive) | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. (Aorist) · Perf. (Perfect) | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Commentary Point	Review
I.A — Public Confrontation	Paul confronted Peter face to face, in front of everyone, rather than privately — because the sin itself was public.

Commentary Point	Review
I.B-C — Pointed & Poisonous	Peter's withdrawal from the Gentiles was gradual (imperfect tense), and it was contagious — even Barnabas was carried away.
II.B — Justification by Faith	Justification is forensic (legal) — a declaration of "not guilty," received by faith, not earned by law-keeping.
III.B-C — Dead to the Law, Alive to God	Believers died to the law's claim through the cross, and now live a new life by faith in the Son of God, not by law.
III.D — Necessity of Grace	If righteousness could come through the law, Christ's death would have been unnecessary — grace is the only way.

Part 2 — Discussion Questions

1. Peter already knew the truth — he had seen the vision, felt the Spirit fall on Cornelius's household, and even preached and promised to live by it. What made him withdraw from the Gentiles anyway?

Leader answer: Fear of man — “fearing those who were of the circumcision” (v.12). Knowledge alone did not protect Peter from social pressure; neither does it protect us. Leader note: draw out that this was gradual (imperfect tense), not a sudden reversal — small compromises accumulate.

2. Why did Paul confront Peter publicly, “before them all,” rather than privately?

Leader answer: Because the sin was public and had already misled others (v.13). Dr. Ryrrie's principle applies: confession/correction should be as public as the sin. Leader note: distinguish this from gossip or humiliation — the goal was protecting the gospel's clarity for the whole church, not shaming Peter personally.

3. What does it mean that justification is “forensic” or legal (2:16)? Why does the courtroom illustration in the Commentary matter?

Leader answer: It means God's declaration of righteousness is a legal verdict, not a gradual moral improvement. Like a “not guilty” verdict, it is final and cannot be retried. Leader note: distinguish justification (once for all, positional) from ongoing sanctification/fellowship (1 John 1:9).

4. In what sense had Paul “died to the law” (2:19), and why does he say this is a good thing?

Leader answer: The law's purpose was to point to Christ; when Christ died, the law's jurisdiction over the believer ended too (Col. 2:14; cf. Gal. 3:19). This frees the believer to live to God directly, by faith, rather than through law-keeping. Leader note: this is freedom from the law as a system of acceptance with God, not license to sin.

5. Galatians 2:20 says Paul is both dead and alive. What is dead, and what is now alive, and how does a believer today “live by faith in the Son of God”?

Leader answer: The old self — the identity that answered to the law and needed to prove itself — was crucified with Christ. What lives now is Christ's life in the believer, sustained by ongoing faith,

not performance. Leader note: connect to the Devotional's reflection questions on fear of man vs. resting in Christ.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verses	What Happens	Theological Point
2:11-12	Peter withdraws from eating with Gentiles when men from James arrive.	Fear of man can override known truth, even in a mature leader.
2:13	Other Jewish believers, including Barnabas, follow Peter's example.	Hypocrisy spreads through a community by imitation.
2:14	Paul confronts Peter publicly for not walking straight with the gospel.	Public gospel error requires public, loving correction.
2:15-16	Paul states that no one, Jew or Gentile, is justified by works of the law.	Justification is by faith in Christ alone, apart from law-keeping.
2:17-19	Paul answers the charge that grace makes Christ a minister of sin.	Returning to the law after being freed by Christ makes one a transgressor.
2:20-21	Paul describes his co-crucifixion and resurrection life in Christ.	The believer's new life is sustained by faith, not law; grace is not optional.

⑤ APPLICATION · Personal and corporate response

1. When Doing Right Costs You Socially

Galatians 2:12-13 — “he withdrew and separated himself, fearing those who were of the circumcision.”

Source: Commentary ③, Section I.B-C

Peter's failure wasn't a change of belief — it was a failure of nerve. He let a room full of visitors quietly rearrange his obedience, one meal at a time. Most compromise doesn't announce itself; it arrives gradually, the way Peter's withdrawal did, meal by meal, until a whole congregation had reorganized itself around someone else's expectations instead of the gospel.

Reflection: Where has your practice quietly drifted from what you actually believe, because it was easier than the social cost of staying consistent?

Practical Step: Name one place this week where you've been managing others' opinions instead of living out what you already know to be true — and take one visible step back toward it.

2. Resting in a Righteousness That Isn't Yours

Galatians 2:16 — “knowing that a man is not justified by the works of the law but by faith in Jesus Christ.”

Free Grace theology has always insisted on a clean line here: eternal life is received by faith alone, the moment a person believes, as a settled and permanent gift — not a status maintained by performance. The courtroom illustration in the Commentary makes this concrete: a “not guilty”

verdict is not provisional. If you are trusting Christ, that verdict already stands, regardless of how today went.

Reflection: Is there an area where you are quietly trying to re-earn a standing with God that Christ already secured for you by faith?

Practical Step: Write down one specific way you've been treating God's acceptance as conditional this week, then consciously thank Him for the verdict already rendered in Christ.

3. Living the Crucified Life

Galatians 2:20 — “I have been crucified with Christ... the life which I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God.”

Source: Commentary ③, Section III.C; cf. FGR Resource Library — Charles R. Swindoll, The Grace Awakening (Nashville: Thomas Nelson, 2003)

Sanctification runs on the same fuel as salvation: faith, not law. Paul doesn't describe daily discipleship as willpower management — he describes it as an old identity that was crucified and a new life sustained moment by moment by trust in the One who loved him and gave Himself for him.

Reflection: What would change today if you approached your besetting struggle as a matter of faith in Christ's finished work, rather than a matter of trying harder?

Practical Step: Pick one recurring struggle and, instead of a new resolution, write a one-sentence prayer of faith in Christ's love and finished work over it.

4. Loving Correction Instead of Silence

Galatians 2:11, 14 — “I withstood him to his face... I said to Peter before them all.”

Source: Commentary ③Library — Charles C. Ryrie, Balancing the Christian Life (Chicago: Moody Publishers, 1994)

Paul's confrontation of Peter was not cruelty — it was loving fidelity to the truth of the gospel, applied as publicly as the error itself. Dr. Ryrie's principle, that confession should be as public as the sin, cuts both ways: it warns against gossip disguised as concern, and it warns against silence disguised as kindness when gospel clarity is genuinely at stake.

Reflection: Is there a situation where love for someone, and love for the truth, both require you to say something you've been avoiding?

Practical Step: If such a situation exists, identify one truthful, gracious sentence you could say this week — and plan when and how you will say it directly to the person involved.

End of Study · Galatians 2:11-21